



Samsung VP-D975Wi PAL

Smooth Operator!

This is the best-built Samsung camcorder in our collective opinion, and it feels very solid to hold. The VP-D975Wi PAL uses DV tapes. The gun grey / dark grey colour combination has spawned a million followers, and Samsung doesn't deviate from the beaten path—why change a winning combination? Everything is very ergonomic, and the Samsung VP-D975Wi PAL seemed built for our hands. The menu layout is somewhat of a trendsetter—intuitive, well-laid-out, and simple to understand—you won't spend much time getting easy with it.

This model supports digital IS (as opposed to optical IS), which doesn't do much in the way of preventing or even minimising hand shake; even minor jerks are noticeable. We also

had issues with focussing at the long end of the zoom, where the sensor would focus properly and lose focus—and this would continue. Incidentally, this happened when focusing on on-screen text. Very irritating, but this might actually have been caused by the lack of a really effective IS system too.

The viewfinder could have been better, and after the Panasonic models, the Samsung VP-D975Wi PAL disappointed. The illumination assist bulb works reasonably well to a distance of 4 feet,

after which it loses effectiveness, particularly in dim conditions. Night Mode wasn't very effective on this camcorder, and we don't recommend the Samsung VP-D975Wi PAL if you plan on a lot of late-hour shooting. That said, indoor quality was pretty decent (but far from perfect)—there was noticeable noise, and some discolouration around certain objects. This was due to a strong yellow cast indoors at Auto

RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7
Ergonomics	: 7.5
IS effectiveness	: 6
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 6
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 7
Photo Quality	: 6.5
Audio Quality	: 7.5

settings; once we used manual settings, we were able to rid the video of this cast, but the point remains that most users will shoot at Auto settings.

Rs 18,900 means the Samsung VP-D975Wi PAL is affordable, but a little expensive for a DV tape media based camcorder. Canon's DC210 makes a stronger statement at the same price.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD image sensor (1.0 megapixel); LCD viewfinder 2.7-inches (112,000 pixels); Weight: 1.05 kg

Samsung VP-D371Wi

Entry Points Never Were So Low!

The VP-D371Wi is Samsung's entry point to the world of consumer camcorders, although it doesn't look like a value part. On the contrary, the matte finish looks very classy in comparison to the glossy finish on the VP-D975Wi PAL—and if Samsung deliberately intended *matte* on the VP-D371Wi to look cheaper than a glossy finish, they failed!

Ergonomics are identical to the VP-D975Wi PAL. Interestingly, the VP-D371Wi misses out on SD memory expansion, which means any photos you take are saved directly to the tape drive, which isn't a good thing. There is no audio-out; you'll need to make do with an AV-out and a

RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7
Ergonomics	: 7.5
IS effectiveness	: 5.5
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 6
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 7
Photo Quality	: 5
Audio quality	: 7

FireWire port, the latter being mainly for PC connectivity, of course.

Despite its value orientation, the image sensor at 0.8 megapixels and the 34x optical zoom onboard won't really give its pricing away. While shooting indoors, we immediately noticed the lack of clarity, especially in improperly-lit areas (when we played back the output on our test PC). Sure, the VP-D975Wi wasn't that great either, but the price difference is noteworthy if we're talking about performance. The VP-D371Wi also has focusing issues; we found we couldn't focus on closer objects (up to 12 feet) when using more than 15x optical zoom. At the longer end of the zoom, we couldn't prevent jitter from entering the recording no matter how hard we tried; in fact, jitter became noticeable at around 25x, and by 30x, you won't feel like zooming in further. There's also a lot of noise present, and we noticed a slight yellowish cast under fluorescent lighting.

The VP-D371Wi is damn cheap (Rs 13,900). However, compromising on price invariably compromises on quality as well—in this case, quality of output. If you consider that the Samsung VP-D371Wi is in a price league of its own and if your wallet is severely constrained then *go buy it!* If you had a larger budget to begin with, don't change your mind looking here.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD image sensor (0.8 megapixel); LCD viewfinder 2.7-inches (112,000 pixels); Weight: 1.05 kg

